

STARTER

Field-by-Field Application Walkthrough

Schengen Area - Short-Stay Tourist Visa (Type C)

VERIFY BEFORE YOU APPLY

Fees, forms, and processing times change without notice. This guide reflects publicly documented procedures as commonly published; treat every dollar figure, form number, and timeline here as a starting point, and confirm the current version on the official government site before you submit anything or pay any fee.

Before you start

A Schengen Short-Stay Visa (a “Type C” visa) is applied for at the embassy, consulate, or contracted visa application centre of the Schengen member state responsible for your application - not a single EU-wide authority. It's decided under Regulation (EC) No 810/2009 (the EU Visa Code). Gather the following before you begin:

- Valid passport, issued within the last 10 years and valid for at least 3 months beyond your planned departure from the Schengen area, with at least 2 blank pages
- The completed Schengen visa application form (a standard EU-wide format)
- A recent passport-style photo meeting Schengen specifications
- Travel medical insurance meeting the mandatory minimum coverage (see below) for your entire trip
- Proof of accommodation for every night of your stay
- Round-trip flight reservation or itinerary
- Financial evidence covering your trip - see the Financial Requirements Overview (Essential tier)

WHICH CONSULATE IS RESPONSIBLE FOR YOU?

If you're visiting only one Schengen country, apply there. If you're visiting several, apply at the consulate of your “main destination” - generally wherever you'll spend the most nights, or wherever your main purpose of travel is. If your time is split evenly with no clear main purpose, apply at the consulate of whichever country you'll enter first. Applying at the wrong consulate is a real, avoidable cause of delay or refusal.

Mandatory travel medical insurance

Unlike some other countries' visitor visas, Schengen applications require proof of travel medical insurance as a hard, checked requirement - not just a recommendation. It must cover medical emergencies and repatriation for

the whole Schengen area, for the full length of your stay, with a minimum coverage amount (commonly cited as at least €30,000 - confirm the current minimum with the consulate you're applying to). Buy this before you apply; missing or insufficient insurance is a specific, standardised refusal ground.

Section-by-section

1. Personal details

Name, date of birth, nationality, and passport details exactly as they appear in your passport. Declare any other nationalities or passports you hold.

2. Purpose and details of your trip

- Main purpose of your visit (tourism, visiting family/friends, business)
- Planned entry and exit dates, and every Schengen country you'll visit if more than one
- Day-by-day itinerary if you're visiting multiple countries - be specific and consistent

3. Accommodation and travel

Where you'll stay each night (hotel bookings, or an invitation/hosting declaration if staying with someone), and your round-trip transport arrangements.

4. Financial and employment information

Your current job or studies, income, and how you'll fund the trip - each member state publishes its own reference amount for "sufficient means of subsistence," which can differ by destination. See the Financial Requirements Overview.

5. Previous Schengen visas and travel history

Details of any previous Schengen visas (issued by any member state), refusals, or overstays. This history is shared across all Schengen states through the Visa Information System (VIS).

6. Pay the fee and give biometrics

Pay the visa fee, and - unless you're reusing biometrics captured for a Schengen application within the last 59 months - give fingerprints and a photo, which are recorded in the shared VIS database.

7. Submit supporting documents

Submit your insurance certificate, accommodation and travel proof, financial evidence, and any sponsor/invitation declaration. Requirements for the exact form of some documents (e.g. a formal sponsorship declaration) vary by which country's consulate you're applying to.